

UNIT 3 · LESSON 2

Why Do People Hurt People?

20–25 min · Week 16

OBJECTIVE Students explore the gap between intent and impact, and articulate that understanding WHY someone hurt them does not mean what they did was okay.

CASEL FOCUS Social Awareness · perspective-taking; intent vs. impact

VOCABULARY why · reason · intent · impact · understanding · not the same as okay

MATERIALS Sammy puppet · chart paper · scenario cards ([Unit 3 Lesson 2](#) cards)

ILLINOIS SEL ALIGNMENT GRADES K-2 · EARLY ELEMENTARY**Goal 2 — Social Awareness & Interpersonal Skills**

2A.1a Recognize that others may experience situations differently from oneself.

2A.1b Use listening skills to identify the feelings and perspectives of others.

Aligned to the Illinois Social/Emotional Learning Standards (ISBE).

OPENING REVIEW · 1 – 2 MIN

Show the "Words for Real Hurt" chart from Lesson 1. "Last lesson: name the hurt. Today: WHY do people hurt people in the first place? And does WHY matter?"

SAMMY · KIND COACH VOICE

"Sometimes when someone hurts me, I want to know WHY. Did they mean to? Did they have a hard day? Did they not know? Does the WHY matter?"

 DIRECT INSTRUCTION

Scripted teaching sequence · 4 STEPS · read aloud or in your own words

01 Why People Hurt People

5 MIN

Build a chart of reasons (not excuses): "Sometimes people hurt people because... they are tired. They are hurting themselves. They did not see what they did. They were trying to fit in. They did not know better. They were scared. They were copying someone." None of these make hurt OKAY — but understanding helps."

02 Intent vs. Impact

6 MIN

Introduce the distinction: "Sometimes people MEAN to hurt us. Sometimes they DON'T mean to. Either way — the hurt is REAL. We can understand the WHY — AND still say the impact was real. Both are true."

03 Two Stories

7 MIN

Tell two short stories using scenario cards: one where the person meant to hurt, one where they did not. Discuss: was the hurt the same? (yes.) Did the WHY make a difference in how to respond? (yes — a little.) Did the WHY make it okay? (no.)

04 The Two-Part Truth

4 MIN

Land the lesson: "Understanding WHY someone hurt me is NOT the same as saying it was okay. I can hold BOTH. 'They did not mean to AND it still hurt.' 'They were having a hard day AND that does not make it okay.' Both. Both. Both."

Sammy: "I can understand AND still feel hurt."

KINDERGARTEN

GRADES 1 – 2

Stay with one story. The takeaway: "Even if they did not mean to — the hurt is still real." Do not push for sophisticated reasoning yet.

Discuss: when someone hurts you, is it more important to KNOW WHY, or to know IT HURT? (Both matter. Different times.) Practise saying both truths together.

EXIT TICKET

"I can understand AND still feel hurt" — say it together. Hold up two fingers — both truths."

Sammy: thumbs-up to every hand. No commentary. Sammy validates participation, not content.

TEACHER REFLECTION

Which students collapsed into one truth (only the WHY matters) or the other (only the HURT matters)? Holding both is the developmental work. Note for differentiated support.

SAFETY CHECK

POST-LESSON CLOSE-OUT · Any student who insisted "they did not mean to" about an ongoing harmful situation — may be making excuses for someone who is currently hurting them. Counselor follow-up.

Did anything arise today requiring counselor follow-up? ☐ No ☐ Yes — contact counselor today

FAMILY CONNECTION

A Note Home

Today we practised holding two truths: "they may not have meant to" AND "the hurt was real." At home, when your child reports a hurt, validate first: "That hurt. That is real." Understanding the why can come AFTER.

SCENARIO CARDS · UNIT 3 · LESSON 2

Print · Cut vertically · Laminate · Reuse year after year

UNIT 3 · EMPATHY & FORGIVING OTHERS · JAN-MAR

Why Do People Hurt People?

CUT VERTICALLY · LAMINATE · REUSE

SCENARIO · 3-C

Why Do People Hurt People?

THE SITUATION

During a class presentation, Tyler made a joke about Samira to make the class laugh. Samira felt hurt and embarrassed.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

- ▶ Why do you think Tyler made the joke?
- ▶ Does his reason make the hurt less real for Samira?
- ▶ What's the difference between explaining WHY someone did something and saying it was OK?

SCENARIO · 3-D

Why Do People Hurt People?

THE SITUATION

After being left out of a group project, Chloe's teacher explained that one girl in the group was having a hard time at home. Chloe said, "So that means it's fine what she did?"

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

- ▶ Is Chloe right?
- ▶ What's the difference between understanding why and excusing what happened?
- ▶ How would you help Chloe understand the difference?

ARCHITECTURE OF GRACE

This is a free preview.

Sample Lesson · Book 1 · The Foundation (K–2)

The complete, classroom-ready curriculum — with anchor charts, worksheets, Illinois SEL alignment, and scripted Direct Instruction — is part of the Architecture of Grace district library. Educators can license the full set; families can find materials in the family store.

architectureofgrace.org